

Open Source Access to MS Exchange Server Using DavMail

This article introduces DavMail and demonstrates its importance in corporate scenarios for accessing mail from MS Exchange Server.



Many enterprises use Microsoft Exchange for corporate e-mail; usually, there's no avoiding it. While Exchange can provide IMAP/POP services, these are frequently disabled citing security reasons, leaving Outlook Web Access (OWA) as the only hope for users of non-Microsoft mail user agents (MUAs). But losing important emails is one of the major concerns, due to the limited space provided by Exchange Server. Apart from this, there are many Linux enthusiasts and government authorities who have now stopped working on Windows due to the increasing popularity of Ubuntu and similar Linux distros. Moreover, organisations invest huge amounts on purchasing MS Outlook for each desktop.

MS Exchange uses proprietary MAPI protocols, which are incompatible with the open protocols that Thunderbird and other clients use. So here's a nice solution that lets you use any email client to connect to Exchange Server with a third-party gateway, in a secure way (optional encryption) and, of course, it's free. The popular FOSS website *SourceForge.net* explains its architecture: "The main goal of DavMail is to provide standards-compliant protocols in front of proprietary

Exchange. This means LDAP for a global address book, SMTP to send messages, IMAP to browse messages on the server in any folder, POP to retrieve inbox messages only, CalDAV for calendar support, and CardDAV for personal contacts sync. Thus, any standards-compliant client can be used with Microsoft Exchange. The DavMail gateway is implemented in Java, and should run on any platform. Releases are tested on Windows, Linux (Ubuntu) and Mac OS X. Tested successfully with the iPhone (gateway running on a server)."

Figure 1 shows various applications using DavMail (the yellow icon) to connect to OWA (Outlook Web Access) and Exchange. Using OWA instead of proprietary MAPI or IMAP/SMTP protocols itself ensures secure communication with the server. For smartphones, DavMail is used as a dedicated host to provide SMTP and IMAP services to those devices, hiding all the server configuration from those so-called less secure Internet devices. It also supports set-up of calendars and CardDAV protocol to sync address books.

We tested DavMail 3.9.9 using Thunderbird 13.0.1 (you can explore the latest versions) with Lightning (a Thunderbird